

WHEN GENDERED LOGICS COLLIDE:

Going Public and Restructuring in a High-Tech Organization

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Gender scholars argued that gendered organizations theory needs updating as organizational logic has shifted amid neoliberal workplace transformations. This qualitative case study of a high-tech firm reveals how features of the traditional work logic remain resilient. I analyze the gendered implications of a high-tech startup restructuring and going public, finding the flexible organization to bureaucratize, implementing specialized jobs and a hierarchy with standardized career ladders. Going public creates conflicting gendered logics that place women at a structural disadvantage, relegating them to low-status, narrow jobs while simultaneously demanding masculine ideal worker norms of visibility and self-promotion. Despite networking, women experience job insecurity and a glass ceiling, while men are assumed ideal workers and advance. By tracing one high-tech firm's restructuring from a startup to public company, I demonstrate how the collision of new and traditional workplace logics perpetuates gender inequalities.

Keywords: *gendered organizations; restructuring; work logic; technology industry; ideal worker; gender*

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Gendered organizations theory has long described the gendered assumptions embedded in organizational practices, structures, and policies that favor men and disadvantage women (Acker 1990; Kanter 1977). Organizational logic fosters masculine ideal worker expectations of unencumbered workers with few responsibilities outside the workplace (Acker 1990; J. C. Williams 2000). But more recently, scholars have suggested that gendered organizations theory needs “updating” to account for workplace transformations like globalization and the rise of information technologies (C. L. Williams 2013, 2017; C. L. Williams, Muller, and Kilanski 2012). They argued that mechanisms of gender inequality have shifted as organizations adopt flexible forms compatible with neoliberalism.

This article contributes to gendered organizations theory through an empirical investigation of the logic of a high-tech firm. I specifically examine the gendered implications of an organization’s restructuring from a flexible startup to a public company. The technology industry, or “high-tech,”¹ represents an important case to study gender and inequalities. Major technology companies like Apple, Google, and Uber have experienced rapid growth and gained international prominence in the postindustrial era, but a series of high-profile discrimination and harassment claims reveals the industry’s systematic exclusion of women and minorities (Alfrey and Twine 2017; Benner 2017). Technical work has historically been male-dominated and socially constructed as masculine-typed (Cockburn 1985; Wajcman 1991), and women remain disproportionately underrepresented in high-tech, comprising 35 percent of the work force, with women of color the most underrepresented group (EEOC 2016). Subtle discriminatory practices and overt discrimination and harassment sustain a “chilly climate” for women in science, technology, engineering, and mathematics (STEM) (Britton 2017; Cech, Blair-Loy, and Rogers 2018; Hall and Sandler 1982). Women must prove their competence in masculinized computing skills, whereas men are assumed to embody the ideal technical worker (Cooper 2000; Ridgeway 2011).

In this study, I ask two questions: How is gender embedded in the logic of an organization operating in the new economy? And how does this logic shape mechanisms of inequality within the context of high-tech? I argue that two organizational logics collide to create distinct forms of gender inequality. As the flexible startup experiences the turbulent transition of going public, the organization seeks to impose structure and control by bureaucratizing. The result is a collision of the new and traditional bureaucratic logics. This study breaks from scholarship

suggesting that bureaucracy would decline in the postindustrial, information age (C. L. Williams 2013, 2017; C. L. Williams, Muller, and Kilanski 2012) and also differs from the suggestion of “hybrid” organizations melding old and new work forms (Brumley 2014). Conceptualizing an organization as host to conflicting gender logics instead illuminates how competing worker expectations limit women’s careers despite their desires and efforts to advance.

I suggest that conflicting logics place women at a structural disadvantage and reinforce masculine ideal worker norms. As a startup, the company embodied “new” organizational characteristics, with a team mentality, cross-functional collaborations, and flat hierarchy. Women felt like valued organizational members with the potential for career growth, even with the company’s fraternity-like “work hard, play hard” culture (Dryburgh 1999). As the organization began to bureaucratize, remnants of the flexible startup persisted, producing conflicting logics that relegate women to low-status, narrow roles while simultaneously demanding their visibility. Going public represents a gendered organizational process, as women experience job insecurity and a glass ceiling while men are assumed ideal workers and advance. This study builds on gendered organizations theory by demonstrating how two conflicting workplace logics perpetuate mechanisms of gender inequality.

GENDERED ORGANIZATIONAL LOGICS IN THE NEW ECONOMY

Building off the work of Joan Acker (1990, 1992, 2006a), a long tradition of gendered organizations scholarship establishes how work organizations rest on assumptions of gender difference, with jobs, contracts, evaluations, and interactions favoring men while marginalizing women (for a review, see Britton and Logan 2008). A key concept in Acker’s theory is organizational logic, which describes the taken-for-granted systems of rules and policies, job descriptions, pay scales, and evaluations that govern organizations yet reproduce inequalities. Workplace policies and practices create expectations of the “ideal worker” as rational, fully committed, and unencumbered by outside (familial) responsibilities (Kelly et al. 2010; J. C. Williams 2000). These masculine attributes of success are often incompatible with expectations of women as wives and mothers, and constrain women’s professional advancement (Benard and Correll 2010; C. L. Williams 1995).

Previous research on gendered organizations tends to center on the traditional work organization. As an ideal type, the traditional logic corresponds with Weber's (1947) "rational" bureaucracy, characterized by a clear hierarchy and division of labor; formalized, written rules and procedures; and rewards based on performance (see also Martin 2013). This logic was typical of the Fordist era of mass production, epitomized by the "organization man" who climbed a career ladder in exchange for a lifetime of loyal service (Whyte 1956). Organizational logic has shifted, however, in the postindustrial era toward flatter, flexible models compatible with neoliberalism (DiMaggio 2001; Piore and Sabel 1984; Saxenian 1994). The new or neoliberal organizational logic operates via self-managed teams working on time-bounded projects (C. L. Williams 2013). Flexibility and adaptability are rewarded over loyalty, with workers required to network to locate opportunities (Brody and Rubin 2011; Kalleberg 2011; Shih 2006; C. L. Williams 2013, 2017; C. L. Williams, Muller, and Kilanski 2012).

To account for workplace transformations, gender scholars have suggested that gendered organizations theory needs updating. Christine Williams and colleagues argued that the traditional-bureaucratic logic has been "transformed" over the past few decades, replaced by a new logic "characterized by job insecurity, teamwork, career maps, and networking" (C. L. Williams, Muller, and Kilanski 2012, 549; see also C. L. Williams 2013, 2017). They demonstrated how mechanisms of gender inequality persist through the new logic, as women struggle to meet ideal worker norms of "boundaryless" careers (Arthur 1994), including self-promotion, networking, and visibility (see also Miller 2016). Brumley (2014) found that the traditional logic has not been entirely discarded, but coexists alongside the new logic in a hybrid form that "embraces neoliberalism and paternalism" (800). The hybrid logic simultaneously reinforces masculine ideal worker standards while framing advancement as merit-based and gender neutral. While there is consensus that workplace transformations have altered the nature of gender inequality, scholars continue to grapple with how to best conceptualize the contemporary work form.

HIGH-TECH AS A CASE STUDY: CONFLICTING GENDERED LOGICS

To contribute to debates on gender and work, I examine the logic of a high-tech organization that recently restructured from a startup to a public

firm. Startups typically embody the new logic, with self-managed teams and project-based work (Barley and Kunda 2004; Smith-Doerr 2004). Being key sites of innovation in the U.S. economy, technology companies aim to be dynamic and flexible in terms of production, structure, and labor acquisition (Colclough and Tolbert 2001). Short-term labor is a conscious firm strategy, with compensation centered on stock options that vest once a company goes public. High labor mobility is common among skilled workers, who continually network and move among competing firms, creating a “high-velocity” labor market (Hyde 2003; Shih 2006). Despite the insecurity associated with flexibility, high-tech companies notoriously compete for top talent by offering “cool” cultures, with perks including unlimited vacation, “no-collar” dress codes, and free food and alcohol (Gill 2002; Wynn and Correll 2018).

High-tech organizations tend to restructure around the process of “going public”—or issuing an initial public offering (IPO) of the company’s stock to the public on a major stock exchange. Organizational restructuring has long been of interest to feminist scholars, who have argued that downsizing and delayering disproportionately increase job insecurity and work pressures for women (Acker 2006b; Rubin 1996; Smith 1993; Woodall, Edwards, and Welchman 1997). Some evidence exists that women fare better in flat organizations than in hierarchical bureaucracies (Smith-Doerr 2004; Whittington and Smith-Doerr 2008). However, other research contends that flexibility masks new or more subtle forms of gender discrimination (Fraser 2009), and that bureaucracy may aid women by providing rules to correct discrimination, specifying evaluation criteria, and disseminating information evenly (McIlwee and Robinson 1992; Padavic and Reskin 2002; Reskin and McBrier 2000).

Within the context of high-tech, however, restructuring takes a different form. Going public is a mark of success for startups, as companies gain considerable money and prestige, but the process is volatile and high-risk. Most firms issuing IPOs are high-performing, entrepreneurial companies funded through venture capital, and going public usually involves changes in governance and structure. To mitigate the risks, high-tech organizations often revert to more-established, bureaucratic ways of organizing (Martens 2004). Rather than downsizing, flexible organizations quickly grow while imposing bureaucratic features like hierarchies, specialized roles and departments, and formal procedures to externally signal stability to potential investors (Baron et al. 2007; Martens 2004).

In this article, I analyze going public as a gendered organizational process. I find that the case of going public represents a partial reverse

direction of Christine Williams's work on the oil and gas industry (2013, 2017; C. L. Williams, Muller, and Kilanski 2012), as flexible startups cohere to traditional organizational forms like those in Acker's (1990, 1992) original work. In high-tech, the traditional logic is not on the decline, but rather bureaucracy emerges during volatile moments of transition—embraced as a strategy to weather the storm of going public. The emergence of bureaucracy within a flexible startup shifts the gender assumptions undergirding the organization, and I argue that the disruptive transition leaves the company with two conflicting gendered logics. This differs from Brumley's (2014) conceptualization of a hybrid logic, which suggests a harmonious cohesion between new and old. Organizations undergoing change may instead simultaneously combine distinct and seemingly incompatible logics, giving rise to contradictory regimes (Vallas 2003). In this case study, going public results in a collision of the new, flexible logic with traditional-bureaucracy.

Going public somewhat benefits women because the company begins to hire more women as it grows, and formalization somewhat tames the startup's fraternity-like culture. However, conflicting logics create career stagnation and job insecurity for women relegated to low-status, female-typed roles considered disposable, dead-end jobs. The organization implements narrow job descriptions with standardized career ladders, but company growth and uncertainty demand masculine ideal worker qualities of visibility and self-promotion. Despite networking, women experience a glass ceiling, while men are assumed ideal workers and advance. In what follows, I analyze three aspects of the high-tech workplace: the gendered logic of a flexible startup; going public and gendered insecurity; and conflicting logics, visibility, and the glass ceiling. By tracing one high-tech firm's shift from startup to public company, I demonstrate how two conflicting workplace logics emerge to perpetuate gender inequalities.

METHODS

Data Inc. (a pseudonym) is a high-tech firm specializing in cloud software, headquartered in a large, Northeast U.S. city. I conducted in-depth interviews with 50 Data Inc. employees and observed the company over nine months in 2016. Data Inc. went public a few years prior to this study, restructuring from a small startup of about 30 employees to employing several hundred people. Data Inc.'s employees consist largely of software

developers with engineering backgrounds, with engineering being the largest, most prominent department. The organization operates via 12 departments, including the technical-core engineering and operations, and more peripheral, administrative departments such as marketing, human resources, and customer care.

Through personal contacts, I was introduced to a woman executive at Data Inc. who permitted me to conduct research in the organization. She assisted with initial recruitment, emailing project descriptions and invitations to participate to approximately 20 employees. From initial respondents, I conducted snowball purposive sampling to remove entrance barriers and to enlarge and diversify my sample (Biernacki and Waldorf 1981). I interviewed workers across positions and departments. Most interviews were conducted in person and on site at company headquarters, in a private office assigned to me. In four instances, I conducted interviews via phone or video call. Interviews ranged from 30 minutes to two hours and, in all but one instance, I audiotaped the interviews with the respondents' permission and later transcribed them for analysis.

The workers in my sample are mostly white, college-educated, and in their 20s and 30s, representative of the overall company demographics and the broader high-tech industry (see Table 1).² I have changed respondent names as well as some personal details such as job titles to protect their confidentiality. Data Inc. is male dominated, and the leadership is largely made up of white men.³ However, my sample includes more women than men in part because initial recruitment invitations primarily targeted women.

My identities as a white, highly educated woman in my 20s allowed me to "blend in" and facilitated rapport with most respondents. Additionally, the firm's large size and frequent turnover allowed me to "pass" as an employee, with respondents occasionally forgetting my outsider status, revealing company gossip or telling inappropriate jokes (Lofland et al. 2006). My identities also shape the data in certain ways: men over 40, for example, tended to be paternalistic, while women over 40 tended to be more guarded. My identities and snowball sampling approach may have limited my access to employees of color, as I more easily connected with company "insiders" (Woodward 2008). I asked two women of color with whom I established rapport for assistance recruiting employees of color, but I still had difficulty, in part due to the firm's lack of ethnoracial diversity and also related to the disadvantaged positions of workers of color. As perhaps the most marginal workers at Data Inc., workers of color may have been especially unwilling to participate because of fears of repercussions or backlash.

TABLE 1: Sample Demographic Information

<i>Characteristic</i>	<i>Women (n = 32)</i>	<i>Men (n = 18)</i>
Race		
White	27	13
Black	1	0
Asian	2	4
Mixed race	2	1
Age ^a		
30 and younger	10	4
31-44 years	14	8
45 and older	3	6
Nationality ^b		
U.S.-born	27	14
Foreign-born	3	4
Education level		
Advanced degree	7	8
Bachelor's	23	7
Some college	2	3
High school	0	0
Occupational position		
Technical role ^c	10	14
Nontechnical role	22	4
Tenure at firm		
More than 3 years	8	5
1-3 years	15	10
Less than 1 year	9	3

a. Five women did not disclose their age.

b. Two women did not disclose their nationality.

c. I define technical roles as those engaged in computing, including the engineering, operations, and information technology departments.

Interviews were semi-structured, focusing on topics of workplace relationships and teams, organizational culture, and work experiences. Respondents frequently brought up changes associated with going public unprompted, speaking at length about their experiences with the restructuring. Eight respondents had worked at the company since before Data Inc. went public, and another seven joined the company within the year of the company filing its IPO as part of a hiring spree. Many other workers joined the company after the IPO but described feeling the effects of restructuring. I also conducted observations of company activities such as team meetings, daily tasks, and informal social gatherings, spending

more than 100 hours in Data Inc. Most observations occurred during business hours, and I presented myself as a student researcher, conducting overt observations, often “hanging out” in my office or common areas, jotting down field notes on a laptop or cell phone (Lofland et al. 2006; Woodward 2008). Observations enhanced my understanding of the organization’s informal culture and underlying logic. I wrote more extensive field notes at the end of each day to record my reactions to interviews and observations. Finally, I read organizational documents located on the company’s website, business journals, and company press coverage for a fuller picture of the organizational history, and to confirm information provided by respondents.

I followed an inductive, open coding technique using NVivo to identify descriptions of the organization and its culture in transcripts and field notes (Charmaz 2006; Emerson, Fretz, and Shaw 1995). From this open coding, themes of organizational changes, insecurity, and shifts in worker expectations emerged. I then conducted focused coding (Emerson, Fretz, and Shaw 1995) looking for narratives of changes as the company went public and thereafter. Emergent themes from the focused coding included “work hard, play hard” culture, layoffs, specialized departments, and visibility.

THE GENDERED LOGIC OF A FLEXIBLE STARTUP

As a startup, Data Inc. embodied the new organizational logic. Respondents employed during this time described working on cross-functional teams to design their state-of-the-art cloud software, with engineers working alongside sales and marketing personnel. Teams typically worked on time-bounded projects, and Susan, a white woman marketing executive, remembered engineers working for “intense, short periods” on a project and then leaving. Paul, a white engineering executive, emphasized the previously flat company structure, with workers collaborating—and at times disagreeing—across levels:

All the people in the company wore a bunch of different hats and did whatever it took. . . . Everybody was on one floor and if you had a question for somebody in marketing, you got out of your seat and you walked the 30 feet to the marketing person. And you asked marketing a question. Or if you had a problem with what they did: “Your marketing campaign just shot me in the foot.” You flapped your arms and raised your voice and you said, “Don’t do that again.”

Job titles distinguished senior- and junior-level people, but the hierarchy often felt irrelevant. The horizontal structure lent itself to a casual environment and leadership approach, with company founders sitting at desks alongside their employees. Workers described how the company's humble beginnings and flat structure created "one team," with workers adapting roles and taking on responsibilities beyond their job descriptions for the betterment of the group. Andrea, a white, junior-level manager in legal, described how the team culture created a sense of belonging and imparted an egalitarian promise surrounding career opportunities, especially for women:

It was a very small [group]—not very small—but it was a startup. It was fun, and exciting, and you did a little bit of everything. Susan would help out a lot with HR because there wasn't any HR head. I'd get involved with planning company parties and stuff because they needed somebody to do it. Now it's gone, people are supposed to stay in their lane, which is good and bad. Good, because I guess you're more focused and have less liability if you make the wrong choice. But also bad because we're all strong women and we liked being part of the business decisions.

In high-tech, intense cross-functional cooperation is recognized as a key innovation strategy. Although some tasks Andrea took on represent feminized organizational housekeeping, such as planning company parties, she also felt "part of the business decisions." The compensation structure may have contributed to the team mentality, as organizational documents reveal that early employees received large equity shares in the company—stock options that vested later, only after Data Inc. went public—common practice for startups to incentivize loyalty. Rather than view the extra work as burdensome, women like Andrea described it as an opportunity to gain additional experience and contribute to the "exciting" launch of the company they shared ownership in. Jessica, a senior-level, white human resources worker, said:

It just used to be a place where everything was super-open, people were given tons of opportunity to move up really quickly. If you showed promise in a certain area, you'd get promoted. . . . There were a lot of young leaders, which was great. It was very much a young company in the fact that it was a little "work hard, play hard," which, um, was fine but it can get weird with people, and I try to not do that.

In line with the new organizational logic, Data Inc. previously lacked standardized career ladders, but Jessica perceived her career as expanding

at a relatively fast pace and both she and Andrea lamented shifts in worker responsibilities and expectations for limiting their careers. Because the organization demanded workers assist with different business facets, workers inadvertently achieved visibility. The human resources director, Akhil, said it used to be relatively common for someone to get hired in one role and advance quickly to a different function. He recalled, for example, the receptionist moving into engineering after just one year. Data Inc.'s small size, cross-functional teams, and intense worker engagement gave workers—and women especially—the visibility needed to advance. However, as Jessica indicated, these potential opportunities often came at a cost, including navigating a masculine “work hard, play hard” culture.

The startup culture rewarded long hours and full-time commitment, and men and women described intense emotional engagement involved with inventing new software. Susan remembered working late nights, fighting with coworkers over small details, and then going home and dreaming about the work: “[We] just all cared so much that when you have a new product it’s like a piece of everyone is in it.” In her twenties and childless at the time, Susan could manage the time demands and in fact “mourn[ed] the loss” of the former “excitement.” Paired with demands to “work hard” came gendered expectations to “play hard,” or socialize and celebrate with coworkers. Rebecca, a white human resources manager who had been with Data Inc. almost since day one, described the ideal job candidate: “We look for people [who are] a cultural fit for the work hard, play hard environment. There are definitely long days, but there are also times to celebrate with teams, and having that more social component.” The ability to work long hours *and* celebrate achievements after work hours reflects a youthful, masculinized standard and excludes workers—often women—with families or care obligations who need or want to return home.

More so, the “work hard, play hard” mentality signals the fraternity-like “brogrammer” culture of technology firms, and respondents described alcohol-centered socializing during the startup days mimicking fraternity culture. Caitlin, a white engineer in her 30s, referred to the company as being “a frat house” and a “boys’ club,” saying, “It was just a bunch of dudes [with] two guys running the show.” She described her boss celebrating company milestones with “The Beer Fairy,” nominating women to cart beer around to desks. Employees would often drink beer together in the office after—or sometimes during—work. Gene, an engineer in his 20s of mixed racial background, said: “Everyone went out to bars and

stuff after [work]. I was hanging out with my coworkers every Friday.” Because the company was not publicly owned, it had more discretion in spending, and workers like Gene repeated tales of “swanky, open bar” company parties. Nick said, “It used to be a lot more fun to work here. . . . Our Christmas party was amazing. We had a summer party on the roof deck of some hotel. It was so fun.”

Women did not similarly glamorize the company’s parties, instead describing how they carefully navigated the “work hard, play hard” demands. Katie, a white woman in her 20s who interned at the company “pre-IPO” as a college student, returned full-time in the IT department after graduation. She said, “Something that really drew me to the company and drew me back actually was that it was really young, upbeat, and work hard, play hard kind of mentality.” However, she had concerns: “I was very hesitant to have strong social connections with people outside of work, just because I didn’t know if it was appropriate. I just wanted to be very professional and be well respected.” Despite being a college student with no family obligations, Katie feared risking post-graduation employment if she “played” too hard. Joyce, a white sales manager in her early 30s, described herself as “very friendly and bubbly,” attending happy hours and sports games with coworkers. However, she faced a dilemma when her male colleagues started to “tease” her, accusing her of flirting. She sought to balance the competing demands:

It’s hard to get respected as a woman, especially in [high-tech]. So, I have the bitch line up. You have to have a really solid conversation and show them you mean business and you want to work for them. . . . But then also have fun. . . . You have to be someone who is likeable. You have to be somebody who is persistent. . . . Somebody who is organized so you can follow all your deals around, and what you have to follow up on and what you don’t. But somebody who can let loose too and have a personality. You’ll be able to take people out to drinks at night and have a normal conversation that’s not about work. You’ve got to be a little laid back, a little fun, but also rigid at the same time.

Joyce tried balancing work and play, recognizing potential opportunities from socializing with coworkers. Yet she articulated the gendered double standards associated with worker expectations: if women chose to “play hard” with coworkers, their actions could be misinterpreted as flirting, and, as Jessica reiterated, “It can get weird with people.” Considering the rampant culture of sexual harassment in the male-dominated high-tech

industry (Benner 2017; Vassallo et al. 2015), women must carefully navigate work events centered on alcohol. While no woman in this study directly mentioned experiencing sexual harassment, their references to the “fratty” company environment point to the industry’s toxic culture that has recently garnered national attention. Despite the opportunity afforded women working at the startup with its small size, flat structure, and flexible work assignments, the organization’s logic privileged masculine ideal worker standards that women struggled to attain.

GOING PUBLIC AND GENDERED INSECURITY

When Data Inc. went public, it restructured, hired hundreds of employees, moved into a larger corporate office, and introduced bureaucratic features. These shifts represent a transition from the new organizational logic toward a traditional model, with a centralized hierarchy and specialized division of labor distributed among departments. Employees repeatedly described the bureaucratic “red tape” or “scrutiny” that emerged as the company became accountable to outside investors and Securities and Exchange Commission (SEC) regulations. On the one hand, these changes created opportunities for women, as the company hired more women to fill expanded administrative departments like human resources and marketing. And the establishment of formal policies and structures somewhat tamed the company’s fraternity-like social environment; for example, the beer fridge endured the company’s move to its new office but was locked during the work day, with only some managers accessing the key. Yet restructuring created a gendered division of labor in the firm that mapped onto an informal status hierarchy, with men clustered in technical jobs conferring prestige and women stuck in less visible, female-typed positions vulnerable to job insecurity.

Data Inc. simultaneously engaged in near-constant hiring and frequent layoffs, part of its recurrent engagement in mergers and acquisitions, creating feelings of insecurity especially among women working in peripheral, nontechnical roles. Caitlin referred to the company’s “growing pains,” and Julia described the “constant turnover.” Elizabeth said, “I think we’re at that weird stage where we’re not a startup any more but we’re not a large company.” The dismissal of the company founder exacerbated this unease, as the Board of Directors replaced him with a new chief executive officer (CEO) shortly after going public. The new CEO overhauled the executive team, replacing some veteran leaders. In response

to these leadership changes, Katie said, "We've had all this stuff happen internally that kind of makes people question what's going on. . . . I stay positive and try to just get through it." I observed two rounds of layoffs during this study, and respondents indicated that female-typed roles tended to be more often targeted for layoffs. In my first month at Data Inc., every employee working on the largest marketing team was laid off (about 20 employees).⁴ One woman from marketing was laid off on the morning that our interview was scheduled, which I only learned as I saw her packing up her desk in tears. Phoebe confirmed that women were mostly affected by the layoffs, saying, "It was all females," while Michelle said, "There were definitely some women impacted in there." The following incident reveals the regularity of dismissals: Two men engineers, both in their late 40s to early 50s, one white, one Asian, were eating lunch in the cafeteria when the white engineer yelled jokingly at a male passerby, "What're you doing here? You still work here?!" The three men laughed and began listing off names, trying to guess who was "still around," making a game of the layoffs. Walter, a white engineer in his 40s, was similarly unconcerned:

There's an old Mark Twain saying, "If you don't like the weather in Cincinnati, just wait ten minutes and it will change." Every time I've been put in a situation where I haven't liked it, I thought, "Well, in a few months it will probably change again anyway," and it has.

Holding the high-status position of software architect, Walter perhaps was less vulnerable to being laid off than others, and in fact was promoted during the transition. Women engineers, however, did not experience the same job security as their male counterparts. Meg, a white director in operations, estimated that about half of the engineers recently laid off were women. She was skeptical about human resource's claims that the women laid off did not possess the right skills or were not "re-trainable," telling me that many of them were "really good." Considering that approximately 90 percent of engineering at Data Inc. was composed of men, laying off a group of mostly women engineers is troubling. While turnover is common in high-tech, at Data Inc. the insecurity is decidedly gendered, with women feeling more vulnerable than men. While going public involves bureaucratization, the lack of transparency surrounding personnel decisions is anti-bureaucratic—as is the dismissal of long-term workers with institutional knowledge. As Meg suggested above, the criteria used to lay off employees was obscured, creating suspicion and

unease, and suggesting that decisions were based on whim or gender stereotypes about skills rather than on systematic evaluations of performance or merit.

Data Inc. did not make a clear shift toward bureaucracy after going public. Instead, the organization maintained and institutionalized some flexible features, resulting in two conflicting logics within one company. For example, executives have private offices with (glass) doors to delineate their status, but all other employees continued to work in an open space. Company leaders regulated work hours, institutionalizing a 40-hour work week. But other practices remained the same, like the casual dress code of jeans and wrinkled T-shirts. And despite the implementation of a clear hierarchy and specialized departments, most departments continued to operate via teams and projects. Taken together, these examples reveal how the organization's logic postrestructuring embodied contradictions, with features of the "flexible" startup conflicting with the traditional, bureaucratic logic to undergird inequalities.

CONFLICTING LOGICS, VISIBILITY, AND THE GLASS CEILING

Workers at Data Inc. no longer wore "a bunch of different hats" and operated as "one team," but instead jobs became narrower, and departments operated independently with many highly specialized teams. Work was organized around standardized career ladders with demarcated rungs, and most employees expected to be promoted within their departments. However, women's expectations of promotion rarely were met because of the collision of bureaucratic work arrangements and ideal worker expectations. Narrow jobs involving little cross-department collaboration created what respondents called "siloes," "high school cliques," and "mini-fiefdoms" within the firm. Visibility became important for worker success, but individuals must navigate a formal chain of command to build relationships. For women, the conflicting logics created a paradox: they were expected to "stay in their lane" and perform limited job descriptions, but their structural locations in culturally devalued positions limited their ability to meet informal expectations of visibility. Women in segregated, female-typed roles often engaged in futile networking and self-promotion strategies, hitting a glass ceiling, while men working in high-status technical departments took their visibility for granted and regularly advanced.

The narrowing of job routines and specialization of labor can be illustrated through the engineering department. Engineers like Brad, a white senior software engineer, often would describe their job responsibilities in dizzyingly minute details:

I'm on the product team. It's about 30 engineers. We're divided into four sub-teams and I'm on one team that is doing [the] Windows product. We are four software engineer developers and three software quality engineers. The seven of us plus our manager and then a product owner are our [sub]-team. . . . The product owner will write in very generic terms, "the product will do this." Very feature, high level . . . Engineers develop it, quality makes sure it happens. Then you have the manager who is more worried about will they be able to do it on time for scheduling.

I draw on Brad's specific, technical language to highlight how the 30 engineers on his team each performed different tasks, including writing new code and testing code quality.

The engineering department also illustrates the implementation of standardized career ladders. Engineers discussed two internal career ladders available: manager or software architect. Project managers oversaw a team of engineers, ensuring they met deadlines. While these positions confer management titles, Brad said, "Architect is usually one of the most senior positions in the software hierarchy," while managers are "communicators" who focus more on scheduling and do not work with technology. Engineers tended to reject management as a goal—including women seeking to fit in the engineering culture. Phoebe, a software developer in her 20s of mixed racial background, said:

Software architect is kind of like the go-to, tech guru. They make big, architectural decisions. I imagine them as like the caterpillar from "Alice in Wonderland," sitting on a poof or something like that and just answering questions. . . . And then there's just management. You wouldn't code as much so my skills would kind of stagnate. I would become more of a people manager. It's good to be able to know the product and be able to advise people that need help. But it is a lot of filtering BS.

I witnessed Phoebe and her engineering team members on occasion teasing their own manager for failing to keep up with their discussions about the code. When engineering departments are in power, they define formal and informal criteria for success in masculine terms.

With “soft” management skills juxtaposed against “hard” computing skills, management became feminized and filled by women. Lindsey, a white woman in operations for nearly three years, described how her boss—a man—gradually shifted her role: “They’re having me do project management now, which isn’t really a direction that I wanted to go, but it kind of came out of necessity because of the [recent changes].” Management roles were considered dead ends with few advancement opportunities, and women shuffled into management hit a glass ceiling as their coding skills languished and they became removed from more prominent, technical work.

The narrowing of jobs together with the company growth constrained women’s interactions in the organization. Workers could no longer shout across the room to ask the company founder a question, nor could they interact with influential organizational members on teams or at social events. Women thus pressured themselves to gain “exposure” with top leadership by navigating multiple social circles to build relationships with the “right” people. Jessica, who above described the company’s former “one team” culture, said:

You can be really, really good at your job and if you don’t form relationships here, you’re going to fail and you will get fired. It’s just a place that exists on relationships. I can’t tell you how many people I’ve seen who come in and act like they can’t be bothered just to get anyone’s input or make friends, and they just end up not working out because no one wants to support you. No one’s going to do you any favors if they don’t like you. It’s kind of cut-throat.

Jessica’s perspective draws attention to strategic networking, a common tactic among women. Kathy, a white manager in finance, described locating company “influencers,” saying, “I often need to hustle to find the connection points and make those relationships.” Andrea, who came to Data Inc. with no technical background, described her strategy: “I kind of made friends with people who seemed to really know what they were doing, just have regular conversations with them. Then when something comes up later about work, professionally, I can go to them.” Despite their strategies, women had trouble advancing. Emily, a white marketing director and one of the more tenured employees, aspired to be a company vice president. However, she was unconvinced she could advance further: “I think I would probably have to get more exposure with the executive team, which has been challenging because a lot of the things I do are

behind the scenes. Nobody really sees what I do, which is why it works.” Without networking with company executives, Emily believed she would remain invisible, passed up for promotion.

Men working on male-dominated engineering teams could more easily access high-status workers—typically other men—and they often took their visibility for granted, expecting to advance. Samar, a senior software engineer from India, said, “You just end up being mentored by the senior people on your team or almost anybody. When you’re just talking about work, it just happens organically.” Men like Samar told stories of promotions “just happening” and felt like the company offered career opportunities. Greg, an Asian American IT worker whose job was his first out of college, was promoted within a year and has since consistently advanced during his five-year tenure. When I asked how he got promoted, he said:

I never actually made a push for it. Because nine months is a decent amount of time, but I don’t know if I had wrapped my head around all of the work at that point yet, at least the concepts behind it and how everything was run. This is my first corporate job so I haven’t really been exposed to this before. I just went on my way, just working and keeping my head down. Someone noticed, which I’m grateful for. And I got bumped up. It’s basically been a string of me saying yes [to opportunities], more than me going after anything specifically.

Greg did not strategize to get promoted; rather, he kept his head down until “someone noticed” his work. Although Samar and Greg are both racial minorities in Data Inc., research reveals how Asian men in the knowledge economy experience layers of relative privilege and may not be evaluated by their racial status in the same ways as black or Hispanic men (Radhakrishnan 2011). White and Asian men are in fact the largest racial groups in engineering occupations, culturally representing the ideal competent, technical worker (Alfrey and Twine 2017).

Whereas women felt the need to self-promote and network, men did not mention such explicit strategies, suggesting that visibility came naturally. The conflicting logics posed challenges for women trying to simultaneously perform specialized jobs and promote themselves across the firm. Whereas women experienced a glass ceiling, men often advanced into high-status roles like architect working directly with technology. Although men and women in my sample were equally likely to report expecting a promotion within the next five years, women were more likely to say they would need to move to a new company to achieve their desired position.

CONCLUSION

This study examines the gendered logic of a high-tech firm, revealing that pressures to conform to bureaucracy remain resilient even amid vast workplace transformations. I suggest that when organizational restructuring occurs in flexible workplaces, often found in innovation industries, a collision between traditional and new gender logics occurs as organizations impose control during risky transitions. As Data Inc. restructured from a startup to a public company, it bureaucratized, implementing strict job descriptions, an explicit hierarchy, and formal rules. These traditional-bureaucratic features collided with remnants of the flexible startup, such as teamwork, frequent turnover, and networking. The gendered implications of this collision could especially be seen by the paradox of visibility facing women: On the one hand, going public shuffles women into narrow, low-status jobs with limited career ladders, while at the same time the organization informally demands highly visible, self-promoting ideal workers. As the company grows and bureaucratizes, women no longer automatically achieve visibility through cross-functional teams or companywide social events.

When Data Inc. operated as a flexible startup, workers “wore a bunch of different hats” and “did a little bit of everything,” and women especially valued opportunities to expand their skills beyond their immediate jobs. Despite masculine cultural norms of long hours and participation in alcohol-infused team celebrations, women perceived opportunities in the flat structure, small size, and team approach. This finding is in line with research suggesting that flat organizations governed by networks and teams allow for greater gender equity (Kvande and Rasmussen 1994; Smith-Doerr 2004). Women’s opportunities appeared to improve as Data Inc. went public, hired more women, and implemented more standardized career ladders. Instead, women—even those with engineering backgrounds—tended to find themselves in nontechnical, management roles on the periphery of the organization. As women integrate traditionally male-dominated occupations, they are often shuffled into feminized positions considered low-status, undesirable, and less visible (England et al. 2007; McIlwee and Robinson 1992; Reskin and Roos 1990). While historically project management has been esteemed in engineering (McIlwee and Robinson 1992), at Data Inc. these positions were devalued for their focus on “soft” skills versus computing. Women in this study aspired to advance in the organization, but working in feminized positions with limited job routines and little technical skill development led to career stagnation and insecurity.

The shift to specialized jobs and standardized career ladders at Data Inc. represents a partial reverse direction of Christine Williams's work (2013, 2017; C. L. Williams, Muller, and Kilanski 2012), with aspects of bureaucracy emerging within a flexible organization. I discovered that some of the bureaucratic forms that Acker (1990, 1992) based her original argument around are still functioning in the context of neoliberalism, indicating that contemporary work organizations are increasingly contradictory, with elements of the "old" and "new" logics colliding in complex ways. Conceptualizing Data Inc. as host to conflicting gendered logics illuminates how competing worker expectations can limit women's careers despite their efforts and desires to advance. While workers in the hybrid work organization climb knowledge-based ladders by being interchangeable, learning different facets of the business, and acquiring transferable skills (Brumley 2014), Data Inc. workers had to "stay in their lane," performing specialized tasks to navigate more traditional career ladders. A lack of transparency surrounding personnel decisions, however, cultivated ideal worker expectations centered on masculine qualities of visibility and self-promotion. This finding of visibility expectations corresponds with other studies of the gendered ideal worker in new organizations (Brumley 2014; Miller 2016; C. L. Williams 2017; C. L. Williams, Muller, and Kilanski 2012); however, the organization's implementation of traditional-bureaucratic features is distinct. I suggest that visibility demands collide with women's structural positions in devalued roles to further constrain their careers.

The women in this study expected to be promoted on par with their men colleagues, but their networking strategies could not compensate for their structural disadvantage. Men could more easily access high-status workers—typically other men—and they naturally met ideal worker expectations, regularly advancing in the company with little effort. This confirms that exclusion from high-status networks remains a key barrier to women's advancement in science and technology (Cech and Blair-Loy 2010; W. D. Roth and Sonnert 2010). Lacking such access has emotional and material implications for women, limiting their self-esteem, inclusion, job security, promotions, pay raises, and other benefits (Pierce 1996; L. M. Roth 2006). Conflicting logics reinforce the glass ceiling for women in the male-dominated high-tech industry, while solidifying men's power and status.

Although based on one firm, this study contributes to understandings of gender, organizations, and restructuring. Like downsizing, going public represents a gendered organizational process that negatively affects women through increased insecurity and pressures (Rubin 1996; Smith 1993). Yet going public, especially prevalent in lucrative innovation industries, is also

distinct from downsizing. While downsizing often involves delayering management, decentralizing responsibilities, and cutting jobs in women-concentrated functions (Acker 2006b; Kvande 2002), companies going public experience rapid growth, expand feminized administrative roles, and bureaucratize. C. L. Williams (2013, 2017) argued that traditional bureaucracies are no longer relevant in the new, postindustrial economy. I contend that this claim must be revised to account for how processes of organizational restructuring shape the gendered logic of contemporary work organizations. Future research should explore other contexts of organizational restructuring, particularly in settings where workers may possess less class and racial privilege. Nonetheless, high-tech represents an important starting point to explore the shifting gendered logic of work, because the way gender infuses pioneering technology firms will likely influence gender dynamics more broadly in the labor market, as other industries and organizations seek to reconstruct their practices.

NOTES

1. The U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics defines the high-tech sector as composed of industries having high concentrations of STEM workers (Wolf and Terrell 2016; see also EEOC 2016) including engineers, IT workers, and computer scientists. While high-tech overlaps with other STEM fields, Alfrey and Twine (2017) note two important distinctions: skills required for software jobs can be self-taught; and tech firms often rely on corporate discourses of being democratic, progressive, or “making the world a better place” (29–30).

2. Despite initial promises from human resources personnel and my repeated requests, I was never provided access to institutional documents or full company demographic information. High-tech companies have been reluctant to release information that could illuminate patterns of bias and discrimination. In 2017, 80 percent of Google’s technical employees were men, 53 percent were white, and 39 percent were Asian (Google 2017). Other high-tech companies have similar demographics. Data Inc. does publicly file an annual 10-K report, which includes information on management, compensation data, a summary of mergers and acquisitions, and brief employee information.

3. To protect the company’s identity, I have not included the exact percentages of men in leadership. Data Inc.’s numbers are consistent with other U.S. high-tech companies, with women holding 11 percent of board and 14 percent of senior management positions (Ashcraft and Blithe 2010). Additionally, whites hold more than 83 percent of high-tech executive positions (EEOC 2016).

4. Data Inc.’s director of human resources estimated the marketing department was 80 percent women.

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